

Chapter 4

Saturday Mornings on Splinter Street

Shortly after, another fiery boom went off. It came from the kitchen. Cody got up and crept out to his family's small, homely kitchen, expecting to see his dad around the corner trying a disastrous new recipe. Much to his surprise, around the corner was his sister Olive making waffles with a chemistry lab set.

Olive Overture was a curious tryhard who had a brain too big for her small head. Growing up in the middle of nowhere with all the encyclopedias and equipment manuals she could read, she had picked up a bunch of useless knowledge throughout the 12 years she had lived. While most kids her age spoke in internet slang and TV show quotes, little Olive was sharing her profound thoughts on the economy, history, and the weather... the stinking weather. She was unapologetically herself, but she still took a lot after her family. Other times, she straight up took her family's belongings. Right now, she was wearing her mom's apron, her dad's old baseball cap, and Cody's new trout sweater.

"Oh fooey," she remarked, "This waffle recipe's gonna be the absolute death of me."

While Cody was thankful to eat something vegetarian after witnessing the slaughter of a creature, he was still curious on why his little sister would attempt to cook. She never made anything, not even burnt toast.

"What's with the batter bomb?" Cody asked.

"The first batch I had came out flat. It looked like a sad, plaid pancake." said Olive before blowing a lock of front hair from her face. It just instantly flopped back to where it was. "Anyway, for the second batch, I thought I'd use science and test out some air-expansion methods for fluffier dough."

"There's tried and true methods *in the cook book*."

"Yeah, but those are boring. Now be a good brother and help clean up." said Olive, returning to stirring.

"It's your mess. You clean it up."

"Hey! I didn't have to make breakfast, ya know. Dad went to work early, and Mom's not back from the night shift yet."

Cody shook his head with a grin. He then grabbed a wet towel and started wiping up splattered batter from the walls. "They've been like that all week. Why're you complaining now?"

“Because it wasn’t Saturday all those other days! We already skipped the healthy Saturday Waffles last week, and I refuse to skip it again this week.”

Olive reached out her chemistry kit and pulled out a bright green test tube. Before she could pour even a drop into the batter, Cody blocked her with his towel.

“Ol,if you really want pancakes, sit down. I’ll make ‘em for you. I know the way dad actually makes them.

“With cinnamon and bananas?” said Olive, arching an eyebrow.

“And a little bit of vanilla yogurt. Those are the easy ones to remember. Come on, Ol. Cody winked.

Olive smiled and yanked the towel from her brother’s hand. “I’ll clean my mess then. One day, I’ll be smart enough to run a company that can pay assistants. But until then, I’m stuck doing my grunt work.”

“Dream big, ya goof,” said Cody as he began a new batch of batter. “Hmm. Speaking of dreams, I had a strange one.”

“Did it involve a super intelligent politician-bear who solved the unemployment crisis in our country?”

“What? No! Was that your dream?”

“Maybe.”

“Well, mine involved a giant squirrel who ate a whole village.”

“Sounds boring.” Said Olive.

“It was horrifying! And then... um.... Nevermind.”

Olive’s eyes perked up. “Oh?”

“Yeah. Uh. I thought other stuff happened in the dream, but then I remembered nothing else happened.”

“Yeah, that sounds believable, alright.”

“Yeah, because it’s true.” Said Cody as he gingerly grabbed the first waffle out of the iron.

“Penny showed up. Didn’t she?”

Cody nearly spilled batter all over the counter after attempting to start the next waffle.

“What! No. Ew.” He said.

“And then she KISSED YOU. Didn’t she?”

“What books did mom let you start reading?”

“Was it all slobbery and gooey?”

“Okay, you know what, Olive, you got your wish. Breakfast is all yours. Feel free to make all the explosive healthy waffles you want.”

Cody slammed shut the waffle iron and marched out of the kitchen.

“Where are you going, huh?” asked Olive.

“To work! There’s no politician-bear solving the work crisis, so I can’t afford to lose my job.”

Olive shook her head as Cody booked it out of their small home. The slam from the front door seemingly shook every room. As the snarky, little genius poured some batter onto the waffle iron, she smiled and giggled to herself, “That boy is out of control.”

It was slow for a Saturday at the gas station. Usually, many roadtrippers passed through Lumber Land during that time of the day. But likely due to the mudslides, the work building was like a ghost town. Cody took a swig from the bottle of orange soda as he headed to an early break. He smacked his lips with a scowl. He didn’t want to like orange soda anymore. It reminded him of failure and pain. Unfortunately, orange soda was too addicting to wean off.

Right as he stood to check on his head wound from last night, a clumsy hand smacked the half-drunk bottle right from his grip. Not to his surprise, it was his co-worker, Chris Lief Clover. He was half black, half Irish, and always out of luck. This boy was even smaller than Cody, and yet he still had the guts to mess with him every now and then.

“You know orange soda stains don’t go away from sanitizer. You need the big boy chemicals to get ‘em out.” said Chris. “And you’re putting that in your body!”

“Worse stuff has entered it, like your mom’s lasagna.”

“Hey, no one else got sick from it. Your stomach’s just weak.”

“Or maybe Irish mothers should stick to making Corn Beef.”

“Come on, man! Why’d ya have to go there? She does Irish cuisine better than your mom does Mexican food.”

“My mom’s Costa Rican!” Cody burst out. “You could’ve just said tacos and been accurate.”

“Sh-shhut up. Your stomach’s WEAK.”

Mrs. Kumar, their boss, suddenly popped out of her office window and **shushed** them.

“I guess I’ll have to strengthen it by drinking the orange chemicals,” said Cody, shrugging with a wide smirk.

Chris chuckled back and tossed the bottle back to Cody. He missed, and it shattered against the stony ground.

“HEY!!” shouted Mrs. Kumar.

The cocky smile from Chris’ face disappeared in a flash. “Uhh s-sorry, Mrs. Kumar. I’ll clean it up immediately.”

As Chris scurried to grab a bucket full of cleaning supplies, Cody went to clock back in.

“How did things go with Penny!?” Chris called out from around the corner.

Right after she was out of his mind, her name just had to be brought up again!

Cody froze in place. “Ummm, she got lost at sea.”

“Don’t be stupid. Did she say yes?”

Cody could hear the sly grin on Chris. He groaned and sighed before responding. “A lot of things. And the more I think about it, the less I want to remember.”

“That’s your body recovering from the pain, bro.” Chris said while sweeping the broken glass. “Did she seem grossed out? Or did she tense up like a deer in headlights?”

“None of that. She just - in the most casual way possible - stated how a simple hangout was impossible.”

“Dang, most girls usually take the casual hangout.”

Cody faintly nodded, trying to conceal his heartbreak from showing.

“She probably likes guys who actually focus on their work”, said Ria as she stepped in to grab a stack of newspapers.

“We’re on break.” Said Cody

“I’m not.” Said Chris.

Ria glared at the two with eyes that burned with the rage of a 1000 suns. Then she shut them and turned herself around in disbelief. “I didn’t hear that. I didn’t see you.” she said.

“Hey Ria,” called out Cody. “How long does it take for a girl to realize they like a man?”

“You’re still going on about Penelope?”

Cody and Chris went absolutely still.

“She goes by Penny.” Cody muttered.

“Oh my gosh, you are! Cody, stay away from her!”

“I’m trying to. But-”

“No ‘buts!’ You have more important things to worry about in life.” said Ria, rolling her eyes. She faced Chris and continued, “Did you know this guy bested a monster of fire last night?”

“Wait, what!” Cody panicked.

“He beat him like a matador. Genius!” Ria said to Chris.

“Code, I didn’t know you had that in ya!”

“No one was supposed to see that!”

“Technically, I can’t ever see it-- but I saw fire sparks and smoke coming from the construction zone! You totally prevented a wildfire from happening.”

“Is that true, Code?”

Cody stumbled over his words as he rushed to a response. “R-ria didn’t s-see anything. And you didn’t hear anything, Chris! Also, the forest was never in danger of a wildfire. The whole area was wet.”

“Cody, don’t talk yourself down like that. You’re a monster hunter! You should be chasing DEMONS, not women.”

Chris was about to make a joke, but Ria stopped him. “Shush! We all know the joke you’re gonna say, and it’s not gonna be funny.”

“Hey, when you talk about monster hunting, can you make sure you’re a little louder so the customers outside can ALSO HEAR YOU!”

“What customers?” Ria retorted. “And you’re embarrassed about monster hunting?”

“I’ve never hunted a monster in real life. And no, it’s A SECRET.”

“Your crush on Penny should be a secret. Did you know she skipped her delivery today?” Ria groaned.

“Seriously?”

“Yeah. She never showed up.”

“But I saw her earlier.”

“Stalking now? I see.” said Ria, as she stepped out of the breakroom.

Cody followed her into the cashier counter. “No, she almost hit me with her truck.”

“Wow. It’s astonishing what us gals have to go through to let a guy know we’re not interested.”

“It’s not like that. She couldn’t brake because of the mudslides. And she was in such a rush, she barely had time to check I wasn’t hurt.”

“She was rushing to ditch you.”

“I know that sounds like a dumb excuse not to talk. But she didn’t seem uncomfortable or anything. In fact, she was talking like I never asked her out!”

“Because she was uncomfortable, dude!”

“She gave me that orange soda bottle.” Cody pointed to the broken bottle as Chris was walking in with his dustpan. “If she was willing to violate company protocol to do something nice for me, I doubt she’d skip a delivery to avoid me.”

Ria paused, and then nodded in agreement. “You might not be totally wrong, but why would she not show up?”

“The roads. She could’ve gotten into an accident.” said Chris. “For crying out, she almost hit Cody.”

Ria nonchalantly shook her head as she opened the register to fill it with a fresh roll of dimes. “If there was a fatal accident, we would’ve heard about it. She’s probably fine.”

“But she didn’t respond to any of our messages!” said Cody.

“Dude, you barely respond to OUR messages.”

Cody remained unconvinced. He glanced down at the newspaper upon grabbing his bottle. Having a hunch something was wrong, he snatched back the paper and started flipping through it, frantically searching for any announcements of a missing teen. Even if the pages came up blank, he knew what to do next.

“But what if I was possibly the last person who saw her-”

“Heed my word, **boy**.” Ria said, slamming the register shut. “Leave Penny Stracciatelli alone!”